

A painting by N. S. Godekar titled 'Four Women'. It depicts four women in traditional Indian attire (sarees) sitting on a raised platform. The women are adorned with jewelry and flowers in their hair. The background features a stylized lattice pattern and a decorative border on the left. The style is a blend of traditional Indian art and modernist influences, with a focus on color and form. The women are shown in profile, looking towards the right. The colors used are vibrant, with red, blue, and yellow being prominent. The overall composition is balanced and harmonious.

Madras checks
In artist Sathya N
Prabhu's series
Checks and
Tumblers:
Madras to
Chennai, a
set of three
paintings
traces the
city's transition
through the
changing
language of the
sari. The works
feature women

Sathya's women are often by themselves or engaged in conversation with another, captured in moments of leisure and repose. "There is a perception that women are always working; even when they are at home, you can see them doing something. I wanted to show that women also rest, when they take time out for themselves," says the artist.

The paintings are rendered in the Nayaka style, drawing from the mural

Karthikeyan Pitchaimallian

Centre's Legacies: Memories, Culture, Traditions - Madras to Chennai, is on at Inko Centre, Adyar Club Gate Road, Raja Annamalaipuram, till September 22, (Monday to Friday) 9.30am to 5.30pm. Entry is free and open to all.

*Rewind will perform on September 6, 6.30pm onwards,
at Museum Theatre, Egmore. For tickets, 9884680688.*

A photograph of two individuals, likely a man and a woman, dressed in traditional Romanian folk costumes. They are holding a large, rectangular textile with a prominent red and white striped pattern. The woman on the left wears a white blouse with colorful floral embroidery and a matching headscarf. The man on the right wears a white shirt and a light-colored apron with a red circular emblem. The background is a plain, light-colored wall.

kind of become synonymous with love; whether through the heart motif or the love we keep pouring into what we make, and the love we keep getting from people.”

Anneeth adds that Péro’s myriad colours lend itself to both minimalist and maximalist homes. “We

7.30pm. Prices start upwards of ₹15,000.

A woman with dark hair, wearing a red and white horizontally striped sleeveless dress, is sitting on a large pile of colorful, patterned cushions. She is holding a large purple and white checkered cushion above her head with both hands. The cushions around her feature various patterns including plaid, check, and stripes in shades of red, purple, and white. The background is plain white.

Péro home will be showcased at The Folly, Amethyst from September 3 to 6, 11am to 7.30pm. Prices start upwards of ₹15,000.

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #69

(Set by Doppelganger)

Across

- Round citrus fruits (7)
- Speed of musical piece (5)
- Ape (7)
- Break out (5)
- Form (5)
- Urge (7)
- Relating to the nerve (6)
- Sensual (6)
- Balcony alongside a building (7)
- Consolidate (5)
- Devastation (5)
- Decrease (7)
- Soothe (5)
- Straggler (7)

Down

- Drug from seeds of poppy (5)
- So long (5)
- Father of your parent (7)
- Picturesque (6)
- Relationship (3-2)
- Drunk enough to be emotionally silly (7)
- Porridge (7)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Solution No. 69

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For creators, the question of who owns a script, a song, a photograph, or an idea can become complicated long before the work reaches an audience. Intellectual Property (IP) lawyer and author Xerxes Ranina, however, believes the law need not be intimidating. His new book, *Who Owns What?*, published by HarperCollins India, grew out of the questions he encountered from clients, friends and people working in the creative industries.

At *The Hindu* Lit for Life Unplugged presented by Prakriti Foundation on September 5, Xerxes will be in conversation with Ranvir Shah, founder- trustee, Prakriti Foundation, where they will discuss the book while exploring the everyday legal questions that creators often grapple with – from copyright contracts to what happens when someone uses their work without permission.

“The book just came out of questions that people, clients, and friends had, where there were a lot of misconceptions about IP,” says Xerxes. “The lawyer’s point of view tends to be very complicated. Even the language of our textbooks is quite complicated, so I thought, let’s do something written in a very simple form,” he adds.

The book talks about the common questions that creators have in their minds – “what happens if I write a script, or if somebody uses my music, these sort of questions people have all the time; I just try to answer them in a simple form using examples, case studies and illustrations,” says Xerxes.

For someone who may not understand what IP is, Xerxes breaks it down into categories like trademarks, patents, designs, and copyright. But what makes it different, he explains, is its “intangible” nature. “When you own a house, you know the physical house, but when you own a copyright of a novel or a film, it’s not something physical or tangible which you can touch and feel. It’s more about what has gone behind the creation,” he says.

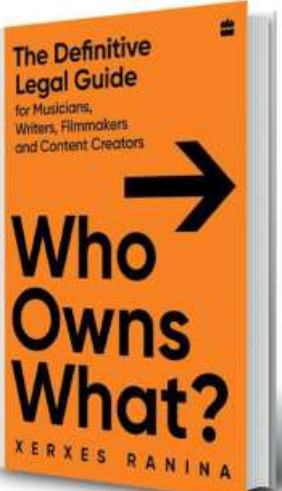
How to protect your IP
When talking about some of the common mistakes that young creators make when it comes to

Mind your IP

At The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged on September 5,
Xerxes Ranina discusses his book *Who Owns What?* and the legal rights of creators

protecting their IP, Xerxes identifies two. First is sharing their work without a Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA).

“Let’s say somebody is pitching a script for a film... they are giving out the script to 10 production companies,” he explains. “So when you are spreading it out, you should be giving it under the provisions of an NDA, which says that it cannot be used without your



permission. The same thing applies for the art world and music.”

The second biggest misconception is that a copyright has to be registered. “A lot of young people feel that because they have not registered their copyright, they don’t own anything. It doesn’t need to be registered; the protection starts immediately on creation,” he explains. However, for trademarks, designs and patents it is different.

On talking about what the red flags in contracts that creators often overlook until it is too late, Xerxes says it is always the “payment”.

“There’s a promise to pay six months later; they will say that they will pay you a share of the profits, and then that never comes. So I tell my clients take as much as you can in advance, or if the project is for one year, have standard payments, so that

every three months you get paid because if the relationship goes bad, at least you get a chunk of money,” he says.

He also spoke about how AI changes the creative landscape where questions are becoming more complicated. “The problem with AI for now is that every month the law is changing. Different judgments are coming out internationally. We don’t have a law currently in India. So we don’t know how it will pick up.”

His advice to young creators would be “just be careful before you sign anything.”



Xerxes Ranina will be in conversation with Ranvir Shah for *The Hindu* Lit for Life Unplugged on September 5, at The Lab, T Nagar from 6pm. Entry is free but registration is must. To register, scan the QR code.



When you own a house, you know the physical house, but when you own a copyright of a novel or a film, it's not something physical or tangible which you can touch and feel. It's more about what has gone behind the creation

XERXES RANINA

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Mark time march

Colours of Glory Foundation, invites university students across India to participate in the all-India online Military History and Awareness Quiz. Teams of two can compete in an online preliminary round, with six teams advancing to the finals. Cash awards will be presented to winning teams. All participants get digital certificates. *Registration is on till October 2 with the prelims on October 3 and the finals on October 4. For details, email info@coloursofglory.org.*



Play your ideas

An immersive workshop led by P Jagan, is a creative exercise that brings together the worlds of theatre and advertising. Copywriter, actor, and theatre practitioner, Jagan will use improv, games, and spontaneous challenges to help copywriters think freely, respond instinctively, and discover fresh ideas. @Ad club Secretaraint, September 5, 10am to 6pm. Fee per participant is ₹6,000. To register, call 8248717152.

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Guiding hands
Students gather after school to spend their evenings at Vidiyal Sudar Trust, a tuition centre, where they focus on education and sports.
R RAVINDRAN

Elsa Sunny
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Between the lanes of Kannagi Nagar stands a modest blue shed. A closer look reveals a lively classroom within. A blackboard occupies one side of the room, while plastic chairs and toys are scattered around the space. Soon, children begin trickling in. Vimal Raj, their teacher and co-founder, Vidiyal Sudar Trust, welcomes them for another day of lessons.

“I provide free tuition classes to children in the neighbourhood. I struggled with my studies when I was young and couldn’t afford to attend tuition centres for extra classes. My own experiences inspired me to start this initiative,” says Vimal Raj.

“Right now, there are more than 25 tuition centres providing free lessons in Kannagi Nagar, and they have significantly improved the quality of education for students in the neighbourhood,” he adds.

For the children, these tuition centres are more than a place to learn their lessons. It often doubles up as a space to meet friends and hang out. “Earlier, we were worried about children being influenced by bad habits after school hours while roaming around. That has reduced now. Students have started coming to tuition centres even on Sundays to meet their friends and play. It is a positive change we have observed,” says S Ashamalini, co-founder, Vidiyal Sudar Trust.

Vimal believes that a teacher’s role in a students’ life is beyond textbooks

More than a teacher

This Teachers’ Day, a look at Kannagi Nagar’s free tuition centres which have evolved into places of study and play



and lessons. Whenever a student drops out from school, Vimal steps in to understand the situation and speaks to the parents and, in some cases, works with the police to ensure that children return to school. He has personally intervened in several cases and helped children get readmitted. Kannagi Nagar, he says, has

changed considerably over the years, with several NGOs providing free tuition classes in the neighbourhood. While education remains a priority, sports is another area receiving attention. Tuition centres also offer free classes in silambam, yoga, and kabaddi. Children from the neighbourhood have already

represented the country at the national level in sports such as kabaddi.

Focus on the extracurricular
Another organisation in Kannagi Nagar working to keep students in school is Turning Point. What started with 18 students has now grown to around 500 students across four centres in two decades, supported by 30 to 40 volunteers.

“Our motto is that no student should drop out because of family struggles or lack of access to education. We also encourage students to take part in extracurricular activities,” says Praveen Kumar S, chief coordinator, Turning Point.

According to Praveen, one of the challenges the centres currently face is the changing attitude towards education among students. “Now, some ask, ‘Why education?’ Many of them are drawn to gig work because of what they see on social media. They watch reels and start adapting that lifestyle. We try to create awareness and help them understand the importance of education,” he says.

Not every child in Kannagi Nagar continues to attend school, with family problems and negative peer influence among the reasons for students dropping out. Most of the students are first generation learners in their family.

Vimal though, harbours big dreams for his students. “My dream is to see children from Kannagi Nagar reach higher positions in Government service. At the same time, I want them to excel in sports and bring recognition to the neighbourhood.”

The poet’s court

How Kannadasan’s grandson teaches basketball, and represents the poet’s ideals

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Legendary poet Kannadasan wrote songs that created an impact on every Tamilian’s life.

Decades later, his grandson, Murali Kannadasan, is creating another kind of change: on the basketball court.

Every evening, Murali trudges to the T Nagar basketball court on Venkatnarayana Road where several young girls train. With the Kannadasan Academy, opened four years ago, he wishes to give back to the sport that once gave him hope.

“I learnt basketball for free. Now, I teach it for free,” he says, as a toddler walks up to him, giving him a hi-fi before heading for a practice session.

Murali has long nurtured his love for basketball, even representing the city, but his tryst with coaching is relatively recent.

“It started with me joining as an assistant [to veteran coach Sridhar]. I figured that as I was anyway coming to the ground to drop my children off, I would support with training the children.”

Today, his academy teaches girls – while the boys train

nearby, as part of the Sridhar Academy. “It took us a long time to get here, but we are producing some of Chennai’s basketball stars,” he says.

The Academy follows a hierarchy system, consisting of K3 (below 10 years), K2, and K1, in order to motivate the players to aim higher. While Kavinaya, in Class III, is part of the K3, her friend, Shivani Shreyas is in Class VI and has been playing for more than two years. “I had no interest when I initially joined, but now, I play more than three hours. Jumping from K3 to K2 was a huge leap – I had to work hard for it – and now, I hope to become a professional player,” says Shivani.

As the sun sets on the T Nagar ground and lights come on, the players are still at it, dribbling, and assisting in getting the ball into the hoop. “Basketball is a stylish game; people sometimes play for the shoes...,” says Murali.

Here, they also play for the jersey – the Kannadasan Academy, named after the Tamil poet whose signature is splattered across the back. “It’s also a way of taking the works of Kannadasan to children. For me, it is a big responsibility to take my grandfather’s legacy into various areas.”



Shooting hoops Murali Kannadasan at a training session in T Nagar.
JOHAN SATHYADAS



Returning to the motherland

Love Thai cuisine? A fine-dining experience at Puducherry, featuring seven curated royal Thai courses will be curated and hosted by Chef Vina, a guest of the Royal Thai Embassy and executive chef to presidents and royal banquets. Chef Vina will also conduct a Thai food masterclass followed by a dinner for 20 participants. They will learn to prepare the Thai hor mok (fish); mok hor (steamed curry king fish); pad krapow (chicken); hu tod sam rod (southern Thai tamarind prawns /cottage cheese); and pad kee mao (spicy stir fried noodle).

Participants can learn to prepare these dishes, take home a recipe booklet, and enjoy a dinner. @The Promenade, Puducherry. The Thai tasting menu is on September 4 and 11 at 7pm priced at ₹2,995 plus taxes. The Thai masterclass and buffet dinner is on September 5 and 12 from 5pm to 7pm costing ₹1,995 plus taxes. Vegetarian and vegan options are available. For reservations, call 9348511998.

Frame work

Explore what makes a photograph memorable at Why Image Matters, a panel discussion presented by the Chennai Photo Biennale. The conversation will examine what makes an image relevant today, featuring photographers Senthil Kumaran, Dhivya Ravishankar, and Ashok Saravanan, and SIGMA India’s Ananthasainan Seshan. The conversation will be moderated by Varun Gupta, co-founder, CPB. On September 5, from 4pm onwards at SIGMA HQ, Kottivakkam. Entry is free. To register log on to chennaiphotobiennale on Instagram.



Madras, through many eyes

A month-long exhibition, titled, The Madras Archive, brings together 20 creators from art, literature, and design. Through photography, painting, illustration, poetry, writing, and mixed media, the event offers a glimpse into the many ways Madras is

remembered, experienced, and reimagined. Visitors can explore the works, meet the creators, and take home a piece of the city, with artworks priced from ₹750 to ₹20,000. @Backyard, Adyar. On till September 30, from 10am to 6pm. Entry is free.

A new chapter

North Chennai now has two new book stores that double up as spaces that spark literary discussions

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In good company
(Clockwise from right) VadaChennai Vaasi; and Maatrukkalam. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Maatrukkalam Book Shop

Maatrukkalam was started as a publishing house four years ago to amplify the voices of the marginalised. “We have so far brought out five books focussing on unaddressed issues and unknown voices from North Chennai,” says author and independent researcher Bhagath Singh, who started the publishing house along with a group of friends. Among their notable titles is *Knockout: Vada Chennaiyin Kuthusandai Veerargal* by P Veeramani, that chronicles the lifestories of 18 boxing champions from North Chennai. The publishing house has now expanded as an independent book store. The store consists of books arranged in shelves along the wall in a 10x10 space. “We have a variety of literary genres by 20 popular Tamil publishers,” says Bhagath, adding that they launched with a collection worth ₹2.5 lakh last month.

From curious passers-by who have transformed into readers, the store has been steadily attracting interest. This is exactly what Bhagath hopes to achieve: to spread the word on reading in a part of the city that is always on its feet. He hopes that people here make time to walk into a book store, an act that has the potential to change their lives. “We now have regular footfall,” says Bhagath, who has plans on expanding the venture into a space that also hosts literary events and discussions, apart from offering career guidance to college students.

“We hope to do that over the next one year,” he says. For now though, their aim is to make more people in North Chennai read.

Located at 3, Apparswamy Temple Street, Thiruvottriyur

VadaChennai Vaasi Bookstore

Started in December last year by N Vijayakumar, an advocate in the Madras High Court, MS Shahjahan, a school record clerk, and N Venmani, an architect, VadaChennai Vaasi has a mix of fiction and nonfiction, apart from children’s books. “If someone from the neighbourhood wanted a particular book to read, they had to make their way to shops in places such as Teynampet or Vadapalani,” says Vijayakumar. He and his friends wanted to change this, making reading more accessible to people from North Chennai.

“For instance, if youngsters here wished to attend an open mic, a film discussion or a literary event, they’ve always had to go to other parts of the city,” he says. Their bookstore has a dedicated space for such events. It is not that North Chennai never had bookstores. “Old Washermanpet has had a long tradition of old printing presses and publishing

houses such as Manivasagar Pathippagam,” says Vijayakumar. “But we wanted to offer something for contemporary readers, such as poetry, novels, and short stories, apart from nonfiction.”

At VadaChennai Vaasi, there are separate sections for political history, fiction, and English titles, and a hall with a seating capacity of 54 for events such as book readings, book launches, and author interactions. “Upcoming authors can use this space to take their work to more people,” says Vijayakumar.

The bookshop hosts literary events every week. “We pick a book and review it; discuss cinema by inviting people from the field; and host open mics as well,” he adds. The store’s highlight is a cosy reading corner. “Books in this section are available for free reading,” says Vijayakumar. “Anyone can walk in and pick a book to read.”

Located at 9, GA Road, Old Washermanpet





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Sikkil Gurucharan has been spending a lot of time by his window. When he is not humming Carnatic riffs, he is mulling over the latest Tamil film song and the usage of classical elements in it. The popular classical vocalist has been putting together these thoughts in a video series titled *Jannal Oram* (By The Window). Seeing the patronage it received online since its premiere in June 2022, Gurucharan also subsequently planned live events. This Saturday at Chennai's RR Sabha, *Jannal Oram* gets a live platform. "It started off as a lockdown activity when all we could do was reminisce and collect different musical ideas," recalls Gurucharan, about the

inception of the concept, "It is a celebration of life, through a Carnatic music lens. Sometimes, people find this form of music to be one filled with rules and rigidity. Every music student starts out with such conditioning, but as we grow up, we realise that everything is connected to Carnatic music in some way, be it films or comedy sequences or life itself. A microphone thrust upon those experiences is what my *Jannal Oram* is all about." Among the most popular segments of the series is 'Classicism: Extended', in which Gurucharan analyses the heavy classical foundations in film music. In this, he frequently explores the work of composer Ilayyaraaja and the vision of actor Kamal Haasan. "Take *Guna* and *Mahanadhi*, two films that initially did not give me a happy feeling," he admits, "My parents didn't take me to these

films as it made them sad. But now, those two films – and soundtrack – have aged so well." Ilayyaraaja's exploration of ragas in various facets is a key aspect of Gurucharan's musings. But that's not all; he also looks for a link in international music, part of which includes a Carnatic re-telling of *Interstellar* as a tribute to Christopher Nolan and Hans Zimmer. "There is a contrast between the scale of a sequence and the simplicity of the music that plays. Like, the 'Cornfield Chase' in *Interstellar*, which is essentially 'sa pa, ri pa, ga pa, ma pa,' an exercise which even a child taking Carnatic music classes learns. But from that, to take it in different speeds and using organs were mind-blowing discoveries." Gurucharan is known as a classical vocalist, but listeners might not be aware that he did sing some backing tracks for

film music composers Vidyasagar and Harris Jayaraj. "I also sung a track for Ilayyaraaja sir in 2006 for a private album that never released. It's unfortunate. But I've always been open to sing for films." He has also acted in a couple of Tamil films – in director Rajiv Menon's *Sarvam Thala Mayam* and his anthology film *Putham Pudhu Kaalai*. "I would love to play characters rooted in music. There is a dearth of movies or OTT shows that promote Carnatic music. What director KB sir did brilliantly in films like *Sindhu Bhairavi* and *Unnal Mudiyum Thambi* needs to happen again; we need more content that showcases the mindset of a musician."

Jannal Oram is on September 5, 10am onwards, at RR Sabha, Mylapore. For tickets, log on to mndn.in

BY THE WINDOW



Nimisha Sajayan in *Babita Singh Reporting*. PRIME VIDEO

The cop's dilemma

A chat with the makers of Nimisha Sajayan's latest OTT offering, *Babita Singh Reporting*

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Nimisha Sajayan plays an unusual cop in her upcoming film, *Babita Singh Reporting*. Joining duty in place of her father after his death, Babita is not taken as seriously by her peers as she is mostly delegated paperwork. Everyone calls her by her nickname, "Baby", and treat her like one too. When she goes to her in-laws place, Baby experiences the brutality of patriarchy in everyday life while she obsessively solves the murder of her childhood friend. There are familiar undertones in these scenes to Nimisha's earlier film, *The Great Indian Kitchen*, which portrayed the horrors of being a home maker.

The actor says that it was challenging to portray Baby's emotions authentically. "I wanted to bring a certain rawness to the performance," Nimisha tells *The Hindu*. "I have seen lots of women, who have shades of Babita, including me. I was just exploring her different shades. That was an interesting process; to constantly discover her."

Nimisha instils a vulnerability in her performance that makes the complexity of Baby's emotions come out meticulously. Baby's journey with the murder investigation reveals darker truths about the fault lines existing in families. It instantly brings to memory the viscerality of *Paatal Lok* and *Kohrra*. The mind behind these searing cop-dramas, Sudip Sharma, serves as the executive producer on *Babita Singh Reporting*.

"I saw the role as, I don't want to say, a mentor," says Sudip as director Ambiecka Pandit interjects. "No, mentor is accurate. He was really a mentor. He facilitated the production and was always there if I needed anything from him to guide me," says Ambiecka.

The film is set in the city of Rewa in Madhya Pradesh and the visuals capture the different corners of the place with an atmospheric fluidity that adds mood to the investigation. "Both the narrative threads draw heavily from the setting and it was important for us to let the setting to become a character," says Ambiecka.

The female gaze is apparent in how closely the film looks at Baby's inner struggles. "It is important to put yourselves in the minds of the character for them to ring true. If the script of *Babita Singh Reporting* was written by me or a man, it wouldn't have those nuances," says Sudip.

Nimisha, who works across languages, feels that she just wants to work with good people in telling good stories. "Language doesn't matter. I just want my movies to travel beyond theatres, cities and languages."

Babita Singh Reporting is currently streaming on Prime Video

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In the 1990s and 2000s, Tamil cinema found comfort in a very specific pleasure – breezy entertainers. All you needed was a simple story, an ensemble, memorable songs, and a good old comedy track to make your day. However, as the years progressed, filmmakers began chasing grander dreams, slowly letting go of one of Tamil cinema's most satisfying indulgences. Audiences have missed the sub-genre so much that even a mention of those films evoke memories of those good old movie weekends. And last week, that feeling of nostalgia heightened for the best reason possible: *Hi*, starring Kavin and Nayanthara, surprised filmgoers by turning the clock back.

Lyricist-director Vishnu Edavan, rejoicing at the film's reception, says making his directorial debut with an old-school entertainer was precisely his dream. "I wanted to make films like the ones KS Ravikumar sir did, or like *Yaaradi Nee Mohini*, *Santosh Subramaniam*, and so on." At a time when most filmmakers are trying to figure out fresher genres to opt for, choosing to do a film so old-school might have attracted opposing opinions. "Which is why, right before I started narrating the scripts, I would tell the listener that I intended to make this film in this specific style," says Vishnu.

The film follows a vulnerable man, Mayilsamy (Kavin), and a sharp, confident woman, Devayani (Nayanthara), who find each other in one of the worst phases of their lives. Mayil falls in



Keep it simple
(From left) Nayanthara, Vishnu Edavan and Kavin. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Going old-school

Lyricist Vishnu Edavan's directorial debut *Hi* revives the breezy Tamil entertainers of the Nineties

love with Devayani, and when a sudden twist of fate threatens to upend their lives, he sees an opportunity to realise his dreams – he hatches a plan that would forever change his and Devayani's lives. If any other director had helmed this story, you could imagine an additional flashback or a few other surprise twists in the second half. Not Vishnu. "Right from the beginning, we

were clear that the audiences shouldn't feel any tension or a sense of urgency; it should be a jolly experience." Kavin's Mayil is a vulnerable male lead and the second half follows the antics of this naive man. What particularly fascinates one is how the late veteran Bhagyaraj is written as the father of a man who might remind many fans of the 80s Bhagyaraj –

timid and emotional. "I wanted this to be a Bhagyaraj film, but in my style. I wanted the hero to be vulnerable, not someone who would beat up 40 people." It gets even better when you realise that the film's only action sequence features Bhagyaraj rolling up his sleeves as he shows a villain his place. "Usually, they would give Prabhu sir a 'massy' role and give Bhagyaraj sir an

emotional one; but I wanted to do the opposite. There, I brought back the Bhagyaraj sir we saw in *Vaettiya Madichu Kattu*," says Vishnu.

Hi is a film that rides high on the performances of the ensemble and Vishnu felt quite comfortable directing his actors. "I left it up to the artistes to do whatever they wanted to convey the emotion on paper. And it becomes easier when you have such experienced artistes in the cast."

Having done the old-school film he wanted to do, Vishnu's next will be different. "I have around four scripts to choose from. But I can confidently say that whatever my next film is, it will be in the zone of films like *Padaiyappa*, *Vasool Raja MBBS*, *Catch Me If You Can*, and so on."



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